

Topic 2.3 - Models for deciding: Rest, and the four-step framework

A real classroom situation

Two teachers watch the same thing happen.

In the corridor between periods, a group of Class 7 boys surround a smaller boy, Imran, and push his books out of his hands. It takes about four seconds. Then everyone moves on.

Mr Khalid, walking behind, does not register it as anything. Boys jostle; books get dropped. He is thinking about his next lesson.

Miss Nadia sees it and knows exactly what it is, because it is the third time this month with the same boy. She also knows that raising it means a conversation with the head, who dislikes complaints, and that the ringleader's father is a member of the school management committee. She decides to keep an eye on it.

Neither teacher acts. But they failed in completely different places, and a model that cannot tell those two failures apart is useless for improving either one.

Explanation

Rest's four-component model of moral behaviour

James Rest's model, set out by Bebeau, Rest and Narvaez (1999), makes one central claim: acting well is not a single act but four distinct things that must all succeed. Fail any one and no ethical action occurs, no matter how well the other three worked.

Moral sensitivity is noticing that a situation has an ethical dimension at all, and recognising who is affected and how. This is perception, not reasoning. Mr Khalid failed here. No amount of ethical knowledge would have helped him, because he never saw a situation to apply it to.

Moral judgement is working out which course of action is right. This is the part that looks like ethics, and it is the part most teaching about ethics concentrates on. It draws on principles, codes and reasoning about consequences.

Moral motivation is choosing to prioritise the ethical course over competing values. The competing values are rarely wicked ones. They are usually ordinary: a quiet life, a manageable workload, a good relationship with the head, the wish not to make trouble for a colleague. Miss Nadia failed here. She noticed correctly and judged correctly, and then the cost outweighed the judgement.

Moral character is following through: persistence, and enough courage to carry out the action once distraction, fatigue or resistance appears. A teacher who reports the incident, is told to drop it, and drops it has failed at this fourth stage rather than the third.

The practical value is diagnostic. When you find yourself or a colleague not acting well, the useful question is not "why was that wrong?" but **which of the four failed?** The remedy differs completely at each stage:

Component	The failure	What actually helps
Sensitivity	Did not notice	Practice in reading situations; hearing colleagues describe what they saw
Judgement	Noticed, reasoned poorly	Codes, principles, worked cases, discussion
Motivation	Judged well, chose otherwise	Honest reckoning with what competes; institutional support
Character	Intended well, did not follow through	Rehearsal, allies, small commitments made in advance

Notice that the most common remedy offered to teachers, which is more instruction in what is right, only addresses the second. Rest's point is that a great deal of unethical behaviour comes from people who know perfectly well what is right.

This also dismantles a misconception worth naming: *if a teacher knows the right thing, they will do it*. Rest's model exists precisely because that is false, and the two teachers in the vignette show the two most common ways it fails.

The four-step ethical decision-making framework: Empathy, Context, Reflect, Action

Rest's model describes how ethical action happens or fails. It does not tell you what to do on Tuesday. The four-step framework is the working procedure, and it maps onto Rest: the first two steps build sensitivity, the third does judgement, the fourth demands motivation and character.

Empathy. Ask who is affected and what this looks like from where they stand. Not "what would I feel", but what *they* feel given what they know and what they can do about it. For Imran, the four seconds in the corridor are not four seconds; they are a standing condition of his school day.

Context. Establish the facts and the constraints before deciding. What actually happened, how often, what has been tried, what the school's rules require, what you are permitted and obliged to do, who else knows. Miss Nadia had unusually good context, which is what made her inaction a motivation failure rather than an ignorance one.

Reflect. Weigh the options against your obligations, not against your comfort. Name the competing goods honestly. Ask the test question: if the reasoning behind this decision were published, would it stand? Ehrich and colleagues (2011) found that teachers facing dilemmas routinely weigh the institution's interests against the pupil's, and that naming that tension explicitly is what separates a reasoned decision from a drift.

Action. Decide, do it, and then close the loop. The return arrow in the figure is the part most often dropped. What happened? Was the pupil better off? What would you do differently?

The framework is drawn as a loop rather than a line for a reason. A decision that is never reviewed cannot teach you anything, and most ethical skill in teaching is accumulated from cases you handled imperfectly and thought about afterwards.

Reflective decision making as a standing habit

Reflective decision making is the habit of treating your own decisions as things to be examined rather than defended. It is what makes the loop above work, and it is a professional disposition rather than a procedure.

Three things distinguish it from simply thinking about your day.

It is structured. "I felt bad about that lesson" is not reflection. "I did not call on any girl in the back three rows, and I think it was because they answer slowly and I was behind" is.

It seeks disconfirmation. A reflective teacher goes looking for the evidence that their decision was wrong. This is uncomfortable and it is the whole value.

It is habitual, not exceptional. A teacher who reflects only after something goes badly will only ever examine dramatic cases, which are rare and unrepresentative. Most of what needs examining is routine, as Topic 2.1 argued.

A practical form: at the end of each teaching week, write three sentences on one decision you made about a pupil and are not certain was right. Three sentences, once a week, sustained for a term, will teach you more about your own practice than a course will.

Activity: Locating the failure

Work in pairs. Below are four short accounts of a teacher who did not act well. For each, identify **which of Rest's four components failed**, and state what would actually have helped that teacher, using the remedy column in the table above.

1. A teacher marks a colleague's relative generously without ever consciously deciding to.
2. A teacher knows a pupil is being bullied, plans to raise it at the staff meeting, and does not because the meeting runs late and the moment passes.
3. A teacher believes that publicly comparing pupils' marks is an effective motivator and continues to do it.
4. A teacher realises mid-year that a pupil cannot see the board, and says nothing because the parents cannot afford spectacles and raising it would embarrass them.

Then swap with another pair. Where you disagree about which component failed, argue it out: the disagreements are usually about whether the teacher genuinely did not notice, or noticed and looked away, and that distinction is the hardest and most useful one in the model.

Allow 25 minutes.

Check your understanding

1. Name Rest's four components in order and state what each one does.
(*Remember*)
2. Explain why a teacher who knows exactly what is right may still fail to act, using two different components to give two different explanations.
(*Understand*)
3. Apply the four-step framework to Miss Nadia's situation. What does each step require of her? (*Apply*)
4. Distinguish a failure of moral sensitivity from a failure of moral motivation, and say what evidence would let you tell them apart from outside. (*Analyze*)
5. Why is the four-step framework drawn as a loop rather than a line?
(*Understand*)

Summary

Rest's four-component model holds that ethical action requires four separate things to succeed: noticing the ethical dimension (sensitivity), working out what

is right (judgement), prioritising it over what competes (motivation), and carrying it through (character). Failure at any one produces the same visible result, which is why diagnosis matters: the remedy differs at every stage, and only judgement is addressed by being told more rules.

The four-step framework, Empathy, Context, Reflect and Action, is the working procedure that maps onto those components. Drawn as a loop, it makes reviewing the decision part of the decision. Reflective decision making is the standing habit that keeps the loop turning: structured, seeking disconfirmation, and applied to routine cases rather than only dramatic ones.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can name Rest's four components and explain what failing at each one looks like in a classroom.
- ☐ I can diagnose which component failed in a described case rather than simply judging the teacher.
- ☐ I can work a situation through Empathy, Context, Reflect and Action and say what each step requires.
- ☐ I can explain why more instruction in what is right fixes only one of the four components.
- ☐ I can describe what distinguishes structured reflection from simply thinking about my day.

Try this at your practicum school

For one week, keep a decision log. At the end of each teaching day, write three sentences about one decision you made involving a pupil that you are not certain was right.

At the end of the week, read the five entries together and ask Rest's diagnostic question of each: had you not acted well, which component would have been the one to fail? Most people find the same component recurring. That recurrence is the single most useful thing this unit can tell you about yourself.

Keep the log private and do not name pupils.

Summative task

Write 400 to 450 words.

Take Miss Nadia's situation from the top of this topic. Work it fully through the four-step framework and reach a decision.

Your answer must complete all four steps, state a specific decision rather than a sentiment, and identify honestly what competes with the ethical course in her case. Finish by saying which of Rest's components your proposed course of action most depends on, and why that makes it fragile.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Completeness (Apply)	Works all four steps, with Context establishing facts rather than restating the problem
Specificity of decision (Apply)	Reaches a concrete, actionable decision that another teacher could carry out
Analysis of what competes (Analyze)	Names the competing goods honestly, including the teacher's legitimate self-interest, rather than treating the obstacle as simple cowardice
Self-critique	Identifies which component the plan depends on and why that is its weak point

Further reading

- Bebeau, M. J., Rest, J. R., & Narvaez, D. (1999). Beyond the promise: A perspective on research in moral education. *Educational Researcher*, 28(4), 18-26. <https://doi.org/10.3102/0013189X028004018>

- Ehrich, L. C., Kimber, M., Millwater, J., & Cranston, N. (2011). Ethical dilemmas: A model to understand teacher practice. *Teachers and Teaching: Theory and Practice*, 17(2), 173-185.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/13540602.2011.539794>

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